



“We want a poverty-free world on a liveable planet”

Ajay Banga, President of the World Bank, talks about the institution’s new vision and mission, reforms, the debt crisis and India’s G20 presidency

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One of the key thrusts of India’s G20 presidency has been the urgent need to reform multilateral development banks (MDBs). And the World Bank features prominently in the New Delhi Declaration. US President Joe Biden is putting in a lot of effort to ensure that more funds are available with the World Bank and is looking at reforming the institution. The man entrusted with this job is Ajay Banga, President of the World Bank. In an interview with *Rahul Kanwal*, News Director of *India Today* and *Aaj Tak*, and Executive Director of *Business Today*, Banga—a former President and CEO of Mastercard—talks about how he plans to reform the World Bank, the debt crisis, and more. Edited excerpts:

Q: I want to start by asking about your mission to reform the World Bank. What have you set out as your mission objectives, given the World Bank’s original priorities in terms of poverty alleviation to try and bring it into dealing with climate finance, food security and the issues that are very here and now?

A: My view got informed a great deal in the three months between being a nominee and getting elected. In those three months, I got a chance to meet leaders or finance ministers of 93 different countries... civil society, private sector companies, asset managers and the like. And that gave me a really good perspective... The first thing I learnt was that the idea of... fighting poverty, and [aiming for] shared prosperity on the one hand, separating it from climate, or pandemics, or fragility, and refugees, or food insecurity, or biodiversity... doesn’t make sense because these are intertwined crises. And when you grow up in India, you realise very quickly that if you don’t have enough rainfall, you don’t have the two crops, you don’t have the cattle because you can’t afford them, you lose your dairy income, you lose the farm labour, and you bring your child back from school to work with you. When you do that, this gain you made in poverty over decades—of getting the girl child in particular to go to school—gets reversed over the course of a few years of lack of rainfall.

The second [learning] was that people feel nervous about what climate change means. When the western world speaks about climate [change], they’re speaking mostly about the emissions-heavy growth of the past. When the developing world speaks about [it]... it’s about soil degradation, biodiversity, lack of rainfall, heat resistant varieties of seeds, catastrophes like